

The Alexandria Catons

Tracing the father of Aaron Caton, tailor of Boonville, Missouri — and finding that the family came not from Fairfax County, Virginia, but from across a jurisdictional line nobody had thought to cross.

Compiled 12 September 2026 Subject: Aaron Caton, 1820–1878

The finding that reframed everything

1850 FEDERAL CENSUS · ST. CLAIR COUNTY, MISSOURI

Alexandria belonged to the District of Columbia from 1801 to 1846. It had been part of Fairfax County before that, and returned to Virginia after.

So a family living in Alexandria across the 1820s left its records in *District of Columbia* books — not Fairfax County, Virginia ones. That single fact explains why every search of Fairfax deeds, wills, tax lists and censuses returned nothing.

The census below shows the split happening inside one household. George W. Caton, born 1800, is recorded as born in **Virginia** — correct, because Alexandria was still Virginia in 1800. His son George R., born about 1828, is recorded as born in the **District of Columbia**. The birthplaces land exactly on the 1801 cession date.

Schedule 1 – Free Inhabitants, District No. 79, County of St. Clair, State of Missouri · enumerated 18 August 1850 by E. C. Davis, Ass't Marshal · Page 4 · Microfilm roll M432-413 · Dwelling 28, Family 28			
NAME	AGE	OCCUPATION	PLACE OF BIRTH
George W. Caton	50	Tailor	Virginia
Sarah A. Caton	43	—	Maryland
George R. Caton	22	Tailor	District of Columbia
Th...	20	Ch...	M...

THOS. N. CATON	20	Clerk	MISSOURI
Sabina Caton	15	—	Missouri
Rebecca Caton	8	—	Missouri

Three further things fall out of the same six lines. Sarah was born in **Maryland**, confirming the state given in Nathan Caton's published biography. Thomas, born in Missouri about 1830, dates the family's arrival in the state — St. Louis first, Boonville by late 1832. And that puts **Joseph at nine or ten years old when the family reached Boonville**, precisely what his 1910 obituary says.

The line

THREE GENERATIONS · STATUS MARKED PER PERSON

- I

An Irish immigrant Caton

UNNAMED

Born in Ireland, likely 1750s. Served in the Revolution and fought at the Battle of Monmouth, 28 June 1778. Died aged 98 — late enough that his grandson Nathan, born 1832, remembered hearing him tell the story.

*Known only from Nathan Caton's 1904 biography. Name not recovered — but probably **Thomas**: George W. gave two sons that name (Thos. N., and Nathan Thomas), and a name doubled inside one sibship normally marks a grandparent. The other grandparent, Nathan Moore, is named in the same biography.*
- II

George W. Caton

DOCUMENTED

Born 1800 at Alexandria, then Fairfax County, Virginia. **A tailor.** Married Sarah A. (H.) Moore, born Maryland, daughter of Nathan Moore of the War of 1812. In Missouri by about 1830, Boonville from late 1832, St. Clair County by 1850. Died 1865. About 1848–49 he "met with financial reverses" severe enough to pull his son Nathan out of college in his senior year — which explains how a Boonville merchant tailor and church steward came to be on raw frontier with \$570 to his name by 1850.

Independently attested in a land sale at Boonville in 1840, as a steward of Nelson Memorial Methodist Church, and in the 1850 census above.
- III

Aaron Caton

LINK UNPROVEN

Born 16 May 1820. A tailor at Boonville, Cooper County. Recorded in 1850 as aged 30, tailor, born Virginia. Died 11 January 1878 at Boonville. Married, late in life, Nannie

Morrison; their son **Gille Lee Caton** was born 18 April 1875 at Otterville — attested in the federal NUMIDENT file, drawn from Gille Lee's own Social Security application naming both parents. A late second marriage implies an earlier wife and an earlier family, born roughly 1845–1865.

No document yet names his father. See the open question below.

Joseph Caton — b. 24 July 1823, d. May 1910. **The pioneer tailor of Brunswick, Chariton County**, and by 1896 a citizen of Salisbury, per the 1896 *Historical, Pictorial and Biographical Record of Chariton County*. His obituary names Fairfax County, Virginia.

George R. Caton — b. c. 1828 in the District of Columbia, tailor.

Thomas N. Caton — b. c. 1830 Missouri, clerk.

Nathan Thomas Caton — b. 6 Jan 1832 St. Louis; attorney at Davenport and Walla Walla, Washington; d. 30 Sept 1916 at Rossland, British Columbia.

Sabina Caton — b. c. 1835, d. 26 Jan 1908; ties to Pilot Grove, Cooper County.

Rebecca Caton — b. c. 1842.

The open question

WHICH FAMILY, THEN WHICH GENERATION

First, a caution about how far the census carries. The District of Columbia birthplace proves something about *George W. Caton's* family. It does not prove that Aaron belongs to that family. Aaron has never been documented in the same household, deed or record as George W.

A second Virginia Caton family — Thomas Caton Jr., out of Fauquier County — was in Cooper County from about 1835, and his father, Thomas Caton Sr., sits in the right generation to have fathered sons in 1820 and 1823. What favours George W. is the trade: he and his son George R. were tailors, as Aaron and Joseph were. That is real but circumstantial, and the Fauquier family's occupation is still unknown.

One hypothesis dissolves the conflict rather than settling it. Thomas Caton Jr. is recorded as "son of Thomas," and the naming evidence suggests George W.'s father was also a Thomas. If those two men were brothers — sons of one Thomas Caton Sr. — then a single family moved around northern Virginia (Alexandria about 1800, Fauquier by 1810, back near Alexandria in the 1820s) before its sons converged on one Missouri county between 1832 and 1835. Both obituaries become half-right

rather than rivals. No document yet connects them. The test is to recover Thomas Caton Sr.'s list of children in Fauquier and see whether George W., Aaron and Joseph stand on it.

If Aaron does belong to George W.'s household, a second question follows. Sarah was born about 1807, which made her **thirteen when Aaron was born in 1820**. She cannot be his mother. Two structures remain, and they differ by a generation.

A chronology that resolves itself. George R. was born in the District in about 1828; Thomas in Missouri about 1830; Nathan at St. Louis in January 1832, with Boonville following before his first birthday. So the household left Alexandria about 1829 and was in Missouri by 1830. Yet Joseph's obituary says he came to Missouri *at age ten* — 1833. Travelling with that household he would have been six.

The reading that takes the obituary at its word: Aaron and Joseph were sons of a **first wife**, left in Alexandria with their mother's family when their father remarried and went west, and sent for in 1833. Joseph then did arrive in Missouri aged ten, exactly as stated; Sarah's age stops mattering, because she was never their mother; and it explains why these two alone never appear in a household with George W.

It predicts a findable record. In the 1830 census of Alexandria County, D.C., the brothers should appear as two boys — one 5–9, one 10–14 — in a household headed by someone who is not a Caton. Under the naming convention that gave Nathan his maternal grandfather's name, Joseph as second son would carry his: look for a head of household named **Joseph**.

Either Aaron is George W.'s son by an earlier wife — George married young, was widowed around 1824–26, and remarried Sarah. The five-year gap between Joseph in 1823 and George R. in 1828 sits exactly where that would fall.

Or Aaron and Joseph are George W.'s much younger *brothers*, sons of the Irish soldier, who lived to ninety-eight and could have fathered children late.

Both place everyone in the same Alexandria household cluster. One record separates them, and it is named in step 1 below.

Cleared from the field

RULED OUT ON EVIDENCE, NOT ABANDONED

Fauquier County, Virginia REOPENED

Set aside earlier on a search that found no Catons in Fauquier — a false negative. **Thomas Caton Jr. was born there in 1810, "son of Thomas," married Elizabeth Lawrey in Fauquier on 6 December 1828, and moved to Cooper County, Missouri about 1835.** Catons were demonstrably in Fauquier, and a Thomas Caton Sr. stands in exactly the generation that could have fathered sons in 1820 and 1823. The competing obituary's "Forkware county" reads as a garble of Fauquier, and garbles run from hard names to easy ones, not the reverse. This is the live rival to George W. Caton and has not actually been investigated.

Moses B. Caton of Fairfax, b. 1767 OUT

A real and well-attested Fairfax family — but the Irish grandfather fought at Monmouth in 1778, when Moses was eleven. Different family, sharing a county and a surname.

The Wheeling cluster OUT

Compiled trees give Aaron's birthplace as Wheeling. But Alfred Caton's family reached Missouri about 1855 by way of Ohio — twenty years later, a different route, a different county. The Wheeling detail appears to be contamination from adjacent material in the same source.

Next steps

IN ORDER OF EXPECTED YIELD

1 The 1820 census of Alexandria County, D.C.

The decisive record. In 1820 George W. was twenty and Aaron a newborn. If George W. heads his own household with a male under five, Aaron is his son. If he is still inside an older Caton's household, that older Caton is the man at the top of the line.

Finding aid — Gary W. Parks, *Index to the 1820 Census of Maryland and Washington, D.C.* (Genealogical Publishing Co.). Alphabetical by head of household, with microfilm page and county.

2 Alexandria artisan records before 1820

The trade descends father to son in this family — we can watch it pass from George W. to George R. If it also passed into George W., the Irish soldier was likely a tailor too. This volume indexes exactly that population.

T. Michael Miller, *Artisans and Merchants of Alexandria, Virginia, 1780–1820*, Vol. 1

(Abercrombie to Myer), Heritage Books. Gives name, occupation, street or ward, and property transactions. Held by Alexandria Library Local History & Special Collections.

3 **Joseph Caton's 1910 Missouri death certificate**

Missouri began statewide death registration on 1 January 1910; Joseph died that May. The certificate names father, mother's maiden name, and both their birthplaces. Free, and it answers the parentage question outright. He was living at **Salisbury, Chariton County** in 1896, so that is where the certificate should be filed.

Missouri Digital Heritage, Death Certificates 1910–1975. Search surname Caton, year 1910 – Chariton County first, then Saline, then statewide.

4 **Cooper County deeds and court records, 1847–1852**

George W. Caton's financial collapse in about 1848–49 generated paper: debt suits, judgments, executions and sheriff's sales. **Bonds of that era were signed by kin, usually sons**, and a son who bought in the family property at a forced sale is named on the resulting deed. Either would establish the relationship the paper record has so far withheld. The same search should cover **1878**, for Aaron's own probate — which matters more than it first appeared, because the *Boonville Weekly Eagle* was suspended from 19 October 1877 to 18 January 1878 and so was not printing in the week Aaron died. He may have no newspaper obituary at all, leaving the probate file as the only Cooper County record likely to name his family.

Searchable free through FamilySearch Labs' full-text search of US land and probate records, which reads handwriting: query "Caton", Cooper County, Missouri, 1847–1852.

5 **George W. Caton's 1865 estate**

He died leaving adult children scattered across Missouri and the far west. An administration enumerates every heir in one place — which would put Aaron, Joseph, Nathan and Thomas on a single page, or prove they do not belong together.

St. Clair County, Missouri probate records begin in 1865 (Wills Vols. 1–3, 1865–1921, digitised on FamilySearch). Check Cooper County's Probate Index Vol. A, 1848–1900, as a fallback.

6 **Aaron's children, via their own death certificates**

Every child of Aaron who died in Missouri after 1910 has a death certificate naming **Aaron Caton as father, with his birthplace**. Several such statements, made

independently, would settle Virginia versus the District of Columbia without touching a Virginia archive. Start with Gille Lee Caton, born 1875, who lived into the Social Security era.

Aaron's marriages should both appear in Elizabeth Prather Ellsberry's compiled Cooper County marriages, 1819–1859 (books A–C), and in the Cooper County early-marriage transcription at genealogytrails.com.

7 Two cheaper corroborations

Nathan Caton's obituary ran in the *Columbia Chronicle* (Dayton, Washington) on 4 October 1916; he died at Rossland, B.C. at his daughter's home and is buried at Mountain View Cemetery, Walla Walla. His British Columbia death registration names both parents. Sabina died in January 1908 while Joseph was still living — a Cooper County obituary listing her surviving brothers would name him.

Washington Digital Newspapers carries the *Columbia Chronicle* free; BC death registrations are indexed and imaged by the Royal BC Museum. Also worth pulling: the 1863 Union draft registration, which records each man's occupation and birthplace, for an independent statement of where Aaron was born.

Notes on the evidence

WHAT RESTS ON WHAT

Primary. 1850 U.S. census, St. Clair County, Missouri, M432-413, District 79, page 4, dwelling 28. Fairfax County Circuit Court deed and term-paper indexes. Nelson Memorial United Methodist Church, *200 Years on the River*, which lists G. W. Caton among the stewards.

Published. Biography of Hon. Nathan T. Caton in *An Illustrated History of Klickitat, Yakima and Kittitas Counties* (Interstate Publishing Co., 1904) — the source for George W.'s birth at Alexandria, his trade, his death in 1865, and the Irish grandfather at Monmouth.

Reported, unverified. Aaron's dates of 16 May 1820 and 11 January 1878, and Joseph's of 24 July 1823, come from compiled family trees. A marriage of George Caton and Sarah H. Moore on 5 October 1822 surfaced once from an unreliable summary and should be treated as a lead only.

On the two obituaries. Both ran 27 May 1910 and they disagree on the birth county. Joseph lived at Salisbury; Brunswick was his old town, so a notice there reads as a hometown remembrance. Marshall, in Saline County, was neither — and a paper runs a death as local news when the survivors are local or the death happened there. That makes the *Marshall Republican* the version closer to the family, and it is the one that printed "Forkware." The tidier "Fairfax" may be the more distant reading. An **H. C. Caton** appears in a Marshall post-office list three weeks later, which supports family in Saline County — and means Joseph's death certificate may be filed there rather than in Chariton. The birthplace cannot be settled from the obituaries; it needs the certificate.

the Marshall Republican, 27 May 1910, is free at chronicleingamerica, but otherwise append /ocr/ to a page URL for its full text.

Worth chasing at home. A day-precise birth date for an 1820 birth does not come from a census. Whoever first recorded "16 May 1820" was reading a family Bible or a headstone — and that source almost certainly listed the rest of the children.

Free sources, no account or correspondence needed

EVERYTHING HERE OPENS IN A BROWSER

Documents that could name a father

Joseph's obituary, in full

Chronicling America has the *Marshall Republican* of 27 May 1910. Append /ocr/ to a page URL for raw text:

chroniclingamerica.loc.gov/lccn/sn89066240/1910-05-27/ed-1/seq-5/ocr/

Joseph's 1910 death certificate SEARCHED — NONE

Missouri Digital Heritage was searched for 1910 under Caton and under the likely mis-indexings of the handwriting — Eaton, Katon, Cayton, Caron, Carton, Cotton, Calon, Caten — with no match. Missouri registration began 1 January 1910 and first-year rural compliance was poor; the most likely explanation is that his death was never registered. Treat this route as closed. One false positive to avoid: a *Joseph Mervyn Caton*, aged 11, died 13 November 1912 in Holt County, son of John Caton and Jessie Wilson — an unrelated family.

Marshall Republican, 27 May 1910 PARTLY CHECKED

Page 0824 of that issue was retrieved and its text searched under every plausible OCR corruption of the surname: no Caton. It is a country-correspondence page. The obituary is on another page of the same issue, which remains to be pulled.

Cooper County obituaries, 1834–2010

A county-wide compilation spanning every paper — which matters because the *Boonville Weekly Eagle* was suspended the week Aaron died. mogenweb.org/cooper/obits_1840-2019.pdf, with decade files under mogenweb.org/Obituary/. Two further indexes, independently compiled: genealogytrails.com/mo/cooper/obits_c.html (surnames by initial) and obitsindex.nygenweb.net/mo/coop_01.html

Deeds and probate, read by machine

FamilySearch Labs' full-text search reads handwriting across US land and probate records.

Query **Caton** in Cooper County 1847–52 (the ruin years, when bonds were signed by kin) and 1878 (Aaron's estate); in St. Clair County 1865 (George W.'s estate); and in Fauquier County, Virginia.

Books, full text

Chariton County, 1896 — may carry a sketch of Joseph

archive.org/stream/historicalpictor00sali/historicalpictor00sali_djvu.txt

Nathan Caton's biography in full

archive.org/stream/illustratedhistorkykc00inte/illustratedhistorkykc00inte_djvu.txt

Howard & Cooper Counties, 1883

archive.org/details/historyofhowardc00nati — also split by township at
mogenweb.org/cooper/Biographical/

Johnson's History of Cooper County, 1919

Free in page-range chunks at

mogenweb.org/cooper/Biographical/Johnson_PP_#####_to_#####.pdf. Its subscribers were Aaron's children's generation, and such sketches open by naming the father.

Census

1830 District of Columbia — one roll

NARA M19, Roll 14 covers the whole District, Alexandria County included. Small enough to read rather than index-search. Free on FamilySearch. Look for any Caton head of household, and for a household headed by a **Joseph** containing one boy 5–9 and one 10–14.

1820 District of Columbia

Gary W. Parks, *Index to the 1820 Census of Maryland and Washington, D.C.*, lists heads of household alphabetically. The decisive question: in 1820, was George W. Caton his own head of household, or still inside an older Caton's?
